



The Effect of Perception of Morality on Judgments of Parents



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Background

Perceptions of proper parenting are often affected by societal ethics. A parent who leaves a child alone for a virtuous reason can be seen as better than a parent who does so for an iniquitous reason.

General Research Question: How do moral perceptions affect how people assess child safety?

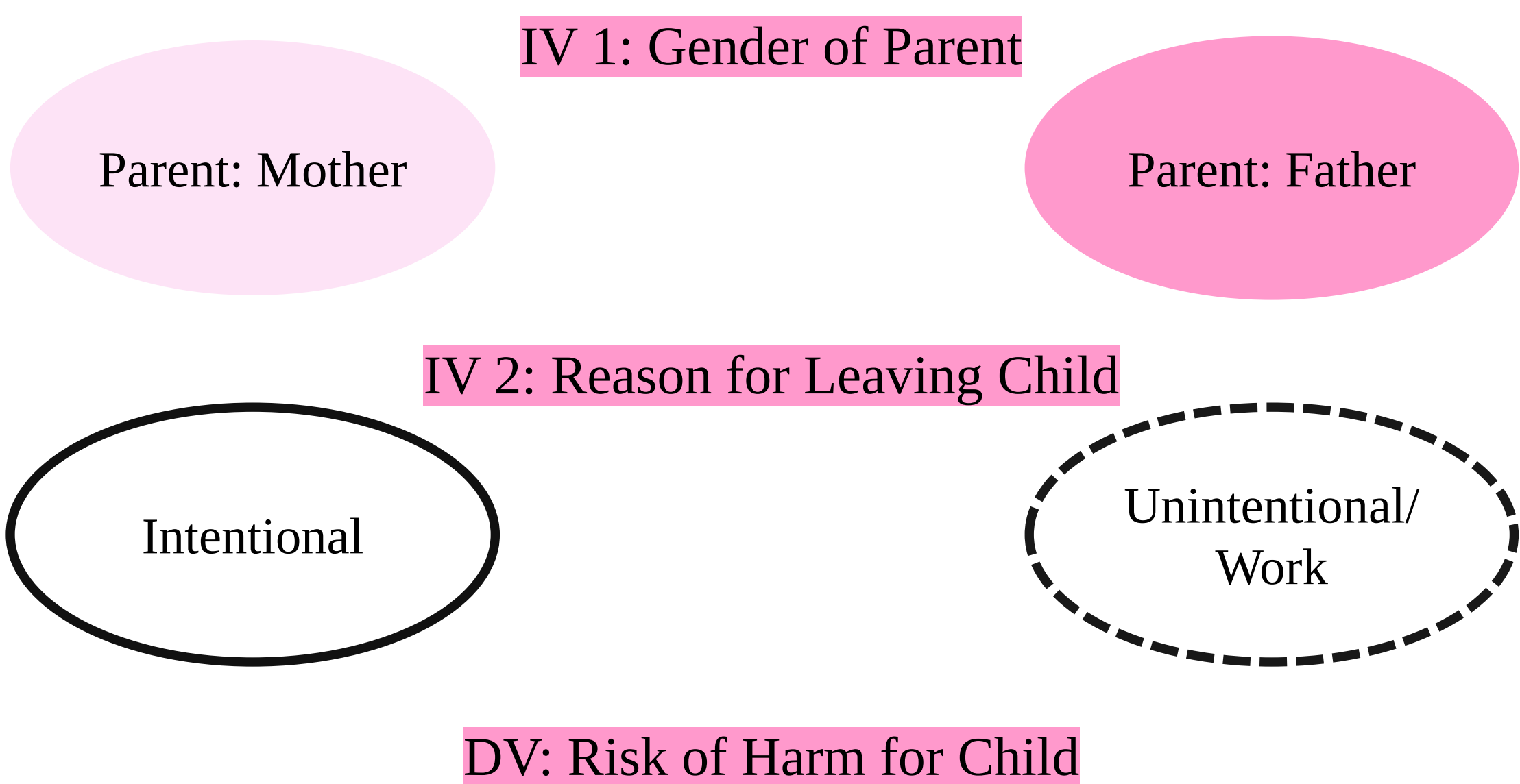
Specific Research Question: Does gender of parent and reason for leaving child affect perceptions of child harm?

Hypotheses

- 1) There will be higher risk of child harm ratings for the intentional conditions than the unintentional conditions.
- 2) There will be higher risk of child harm ratings for the mother conditions than the father conditions

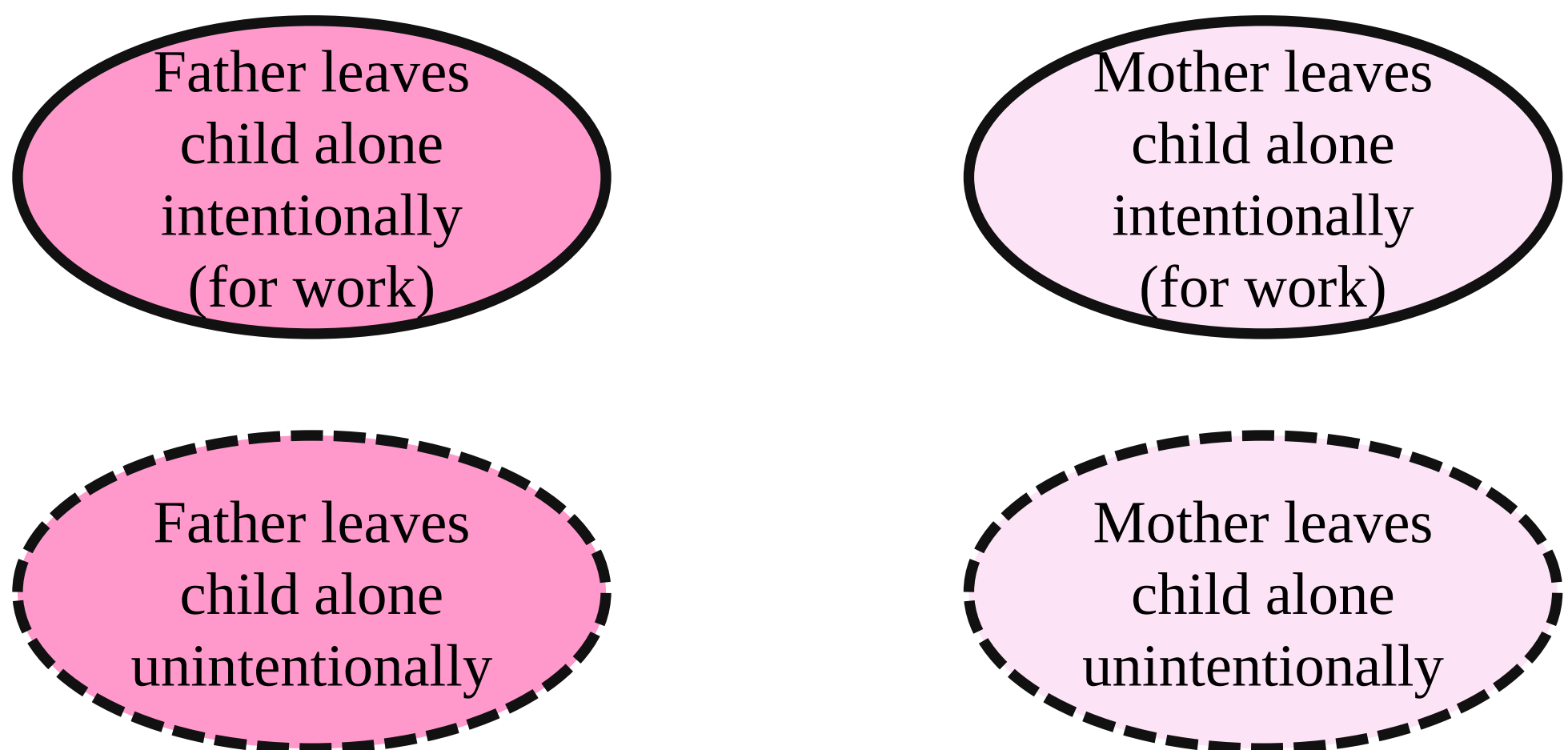
Method

- 186 participants were recruited by convenience sampling.
- 2x2 Between Subjects Design
- The vignette described a mother or father who left their child alone for either an intentional or unintentional reason.
- Participants were randomly assigned to one of 4 conditions and read 5 vignettes and 1 fake vignette.



- Participants were asked to rate risk of child harm on a scale of 1 (lowest) to 10 (highest) for each vignette they read.
- The average was taken.

4 Conditions for the Vignettes

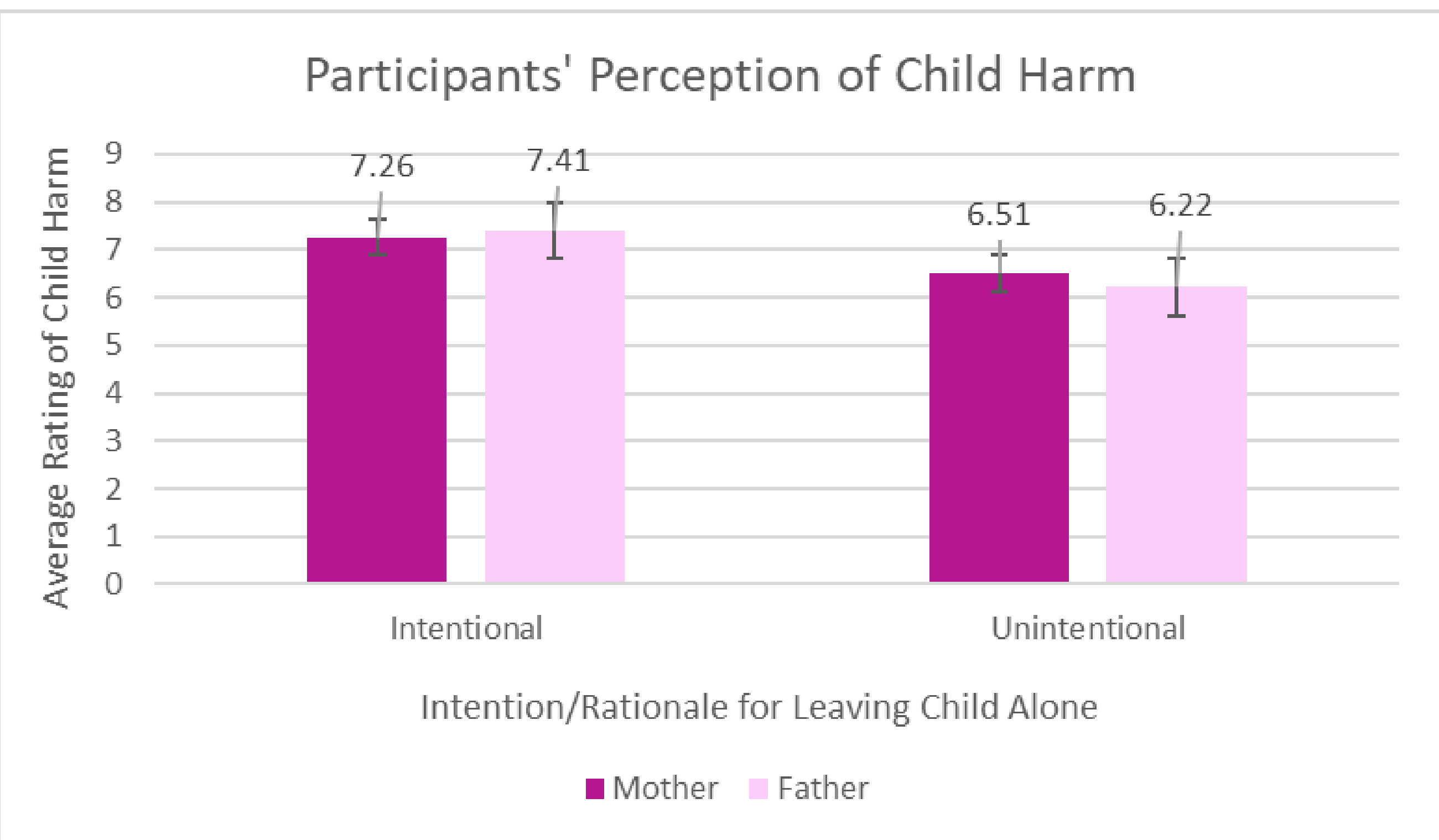


Results

Vignettes where the child was intentionally left alone yielded higher risk ratings than vignettes where the child was unintentionally left alone.

There was no difference in risk ratings between vignettes with mothers versus vignettes with fathers.

- $F(1, 182) = 15.49, p < .001$; there was a main effect of intention.
- $F(1, 182) = .08, p = .78$; there was no main effect of gender of parent.
- $F(1, 182) = .83, p = .36$; there was no interaction between intention and gender of parent.



Discussion

Conclusion

- Participants perceived higher levels of danger for children left intentionally alone, for work, versus children left unintentionally., for an emergency.
- **Hypothesis 1 is supported.**
- Participants did not perceive higher levels of danger for children left alone by a mother compared to a father. **Hypothesis 2 is not supported.**
- **Main Conclusion:** Child risk perceptions are affected by the rationale for leaving the child, and not whether it is a mother or father leaving them.

Limitations

- There was a lack of variety for the intentional conditions. The experiment would have benefited from having additional intentional rationales alongside the work conditions. Other rationales include needing to complete civic duties or routine medical checkups.

Future Research and Action

- Future research should include multiple examples of leaving a child alone intentionally. This will allow for better comparisons of risk perception between low-risk situations.
- The findings indicate that individuals may be affected by their moral conceptions of parenting when assessing child safety. It's possible that many institutions, such as child protection agencies and public schools, rely on an examination of the parent rather than the child when making child relocation decisions.
- Family related issues should have a focus on children rather than a desire to punish parents for wrongdoings they may commit.

References

Contact the author for a list of references.

Contact

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